

India needs more skilled Esports players: Animesh Agarwal

In an **exclusive chat**, Animesh talks about the Esports scene in India and the EWC experience.

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Esports, in the last decade, has shifted from being a leisure activity to a legitimate sport. And one of the pioneers of it in India has been S8UL, which became the first Esports club to represent the country at an Esports World Cup (EWC) in 2025.

In an exclusive chat with Sportstar, Animesh Agarwal, CEO and founder of S8UL Esports, talks about the Esports scene in India and the EWC experience.

HOW WAS THE EWC FOR S8UL?

We expanded from India to eight different countries in the first year, from competing in two games to 12 titles. Everything that was planned for three years down the line, we tried to achieve last year.

Things that worked out really well were that we had two quarterfinal finishes: Nihal Sarin lost to Magnus Carlsen, and Johnny was defeated by ManuBachooore, both of whom eventually won the titles in chess and EAFC, respectively.

We went really close, in a few other games, like Apex, where we qualified for the finals as well. The world saw a new organisation's name, and that too from India, in S8UL.

HOW DO YOU SEE THE ONLINE GAMING BILL, WHICH BANS REAL-MONEY GAMING BUT ALLOWS ESPORTS?

It's very promising — it really segregates us from everything else and gives legitimacy to competitive Esports, because no one can run shady things under the garb of Esports. That was really troublesome for us trying to establish ourselves among the common masses because everything was being termed as Esports.

Most people used to think my company was one of those fantasy or real-money gaming apps. We no longer have to explain the difference.

That changes the perspective of the market and

parents who prevent their kids from gaming, thinking they would go into a wrong direction.

UNFORTUNATELY, INDIA DOESN'T HAVE AN ESPORTS FEDERATION OF INDIA, WHICH IS AFFILIATED WITH THE GOVERNMENT. IS THAT A CHALLENGE?

If you look globally, very few countries have a government-recognised esports federation. If the games are owned by publishers, teams are owned by private bodies, how can a federation, realistically, tell us how to do our business?

Obviously, there could be rules so that things are not legally wrong or harmful to society, but I am not sure how a national esports federation (government-recognised) would help otherwise.

DO YOU GAME YOURSELF?

I started as a PUBG mobile player and was one of the first Indian captains to lead India in Thailand (in PMSC ASIA FINALS 2018). Casually, I've played Valorant; I still play BGMI here and there, but personally, I don't get time anymore.

WHAT ARE THE MAIN CHALLENGES FOR INDIA IN ESPORTS NOW, AND WHAT'S S8UL'S PLAN FOR THEM?

What India currently lacks is skilled esports players across several titles — that will remain our main focus. We have had eras of banned games and problems with computers being too expensive.

Of the 10 to 12 games we participate in now, about half of them are not based in India. We will look to ensure India has skilled players in those titles.

S8UL will try to open up an academy, trying to push more events and tournaments for games where the publisher isn't based in India.

With the Esports Nations Cup coming up, we have to finally form Team India across 24 titles. I don't know if we have players for at least 10 to 12 of those titles in India. So, there is a lot of homework to do, not only for S8UL, but for others.